counter. A peon or an office help, who must have been not more than thirty years old, walked into the post office with a number of envelopes in his hand and stood in front me without even looking at the queue.

No sooner had I asked him to go to the end of the queue and wait for his turn than he started shouting, 'How come these people are still roaming around India? Why don't they leave this country and go to their country?' At the time, I had the physical strength to pin him to the ground in seconds and to tell him, 'Who are you to ask me to leave my country? I was born here and will die here.' But better sense prevailed when I realized that I should not give that individual the dignity of being thrashed in public by a senior Government of India official. Giving him a scornful look, I stood quietly even as the post office staff asked him to move to the end of the queue.

Even a distant state like Bihar could not remain immune to such influences. Sponsored by his elder brother, Amarjit Sohi had emigrated from Punjab to Edmonton in Canada in 1981.There he took a job as a bus driver. He also joined a local Punjabi literary society and became an actor and playwright in a Punjabi theatre group. Strictly opposed to Sikh fundamentalism, he was also opposed to state oppression. Still holding his Indian passport, Sohi returned to India in November 1988 to pursue his interest in drama as a playwright, but instead joined an activist group advocating land reforms in Bihar.

Local police arrested Sohi and his associates a day before they were to launch an agitation (for land reforms). Though clean-shaven, Sohi's Canada connection led the police to believe that they might have captured a Sikh terrorist. That led to a thorough interrogation at the local police station. To his luck, a young lady deputy commissioner with a Punjab background was convinced about his innocence and got him transferred to judicial custody to let him pursue his case in a court of law. He was charged under the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (prevention) Act (TADA). As he was still an Indian citizen, he was denied access to Canadian diplomatic officers.